

University of Glasgow: Academic Quality Processes

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OVERVIEW

- Scotland's distinctive Quality Enhancement Framework
- Focus on enhancement over compliance
- Comprehensive quality ecosystem
- Student partnership approach

SCOTTISH HE CONTEXT

- Quality Enhancement Framework established 2003, updated 2024
- Collaborative development: Scottish Funding Council, Universities Scotland, QAA, student representatives
- Fundamental difference: prioritising enhancement over compliance auditing
- Recognition that as all staff are committed to a high quality student experience, the system should work through supportive rather than punitive processes

FIVE INTERCONNECTED ELEMENTS

- Internal review
- Student partnership
- Public information
- Enhancement themes
- External review
- *Aim:* Full ecosystem where quality processes reinforce each other

FOUNDATIONAL PRINCIPLES

- *Completeness*: All credit-bearing and PGR provision included
 - Undergraduate and postgraduate taught
 - Research degrees
 - Collaborative programmes
 - Transnational education
- *Coherence*: Interconnected system where outputs inform other processes
- *Devolved Responsibility*: The University's staff are all held collectively responsible for maintaining academic standards

MORE CORE PRINCIPLES

- *Objectivity*: External perspectives in every process
 - External academics on PSR panels
 - External examiners
 - Professional body accreditation
 - Student voices throughout
- *Enhancement Focus*: Beyond assurance to deliberate improvement
 - Identify and share good practice
 - Encourage innovation
 - Support teaching development

KEY TERMINOLOGY

- *Academic Standards*: Level of achievement required for award
 - Aims to be constant over time and comparable across institutions
- *Academic Quality*: How effectively learning opportunities help achieve standards
 - Teaching methods
 - Assessment design
 - Learning resources
 - Student support

QUALITY ENHANCEMENT DEFINITION

- Systematic steps to improve student learning experiences
- Reactive improvement: addressing weaknesses
- Proactive development: anticipating future needs
- Evidence-based decision-making
- Experimentation and evaluation

THREE TIME PERIODS

- *Regular Activities* (continuous)
 - Course and programme approval
 - Student feedback and representation
- *Annual Activities* (yearly reflection)
 - Annual monitoring
 - Performance data review
 - Enhancement initiatives
- *Periodic Activities* (5-6 year cycles)
 - Periodic Subject Review
 - Student-Facing Service Reviews and Graduate School Review
 - External statutory and accrediting bodies (where appropriate)

STUDENT PARTNERSHIP MODEL

- Students as partners, *not* customers
- Elected class representatives with formal training
- Representation recorded on achievement records
- Staff-Student Liaison Committees (SSLCS)
 - Student majorities, ideally student chairs (or co-chairs)
 - Multiple governance levels (programme, subject, School, College, SRC)
 - Address operational and enhancement issues

COURSE EVALUATION SYSTEM

- Mandatory questionnaire for all courses
- Standardised core questions + context-specific additions
- Required 'Summary and Response' documents
 - Demonstrates consideration of feedback
 - Shows planned actions
 - Closes the feedback loop
- Student panel members in all periodic reviews

ANNUAL MONITORING PROCESS

- Cornerstone of quality framework
- Comprehensive review examining:
 - Student performance statistics
 - Progression and completion rates
 - Student and staff feedback
 - External examiner reports
 - Enhancement initiative outcomes
- Under ongoing redevelopment

ANNUAL MONITORING FLOW

- Academic units produce Annual Monitoring Reports (AMRs)
- School Quality Officers review → School Summaries (SAMS)
- College Quality Officers review → College Summaries (CAMS)
- Academic Standards Committee reviews CAMS
- Issues addressed at appropriate level with university oversight

EXTERNAL EXAMINING SYSTEM

- Four-year appointments
- Full Board of Examiners membership
- Responsibilities:
 - Review sample of assessment instruments in advance
 - Attend examination boards (at least once a year)
 - Comment on standards achieved
 - Provide comparative judgements
- Annual reports addressed direct to Principal (=President)
- Systematic institutional review with required responses

PERIODIC SUBJECT REVIEW (PSR)

- Six-year cycle for taught provision
- External panel composition:
 - External academic specialists
 - Student representatives
 - Senior university staff
 - Professional services representation
 - External accreditators where appropriate
- Comprehensive self-evaluation required
- Extensive panel visits and stakeholder meetings

PSR OUTCOMES

- Detailed analysis of strengths and development areas
- Specific enhancement recommendations
- Categorised by responsibility level
- Implementation timescales
- Follow-up monitoring at six months
- Good practice dissemination
- Detailed committee review and follow-up queries

GRADUATE SCHOOL REVIEW

- Five-year cycle (four reviews + reflection year)
- Focus on research student experience
- Examines:
 - Academic assessment standards
 - Support arrangements
 - Full student lifecycle
 - Supervision quality
 - Professional development

PROFESSIONAL BODY ACCREDITATION

- Additional external validation
- Periodic review visits
- Curriculum evaluation against professional competencies
- Can include:
 - Staff qualification assessment
 - Resource evaluation
 - Analysis of internal quality processes
 - Regulatory review and changes
- Drives curriculum enhancement

TERTIARY QUALITY ENHANCEMENT FRAMEWORK (TQEF)

- New unified system for colleges and universities
- Six core principles:
 - Excellence in learning, teaching, assessment
 - Supporting student success
 - Enhancement and quality culture
 - Student engagement and partnership
 - Data and evidence
 - Externality
- Annual Self-Evaluation and Action Plan (SEAP)

TERTIARY QUALITY ENHANCEMENT REVIEW (TQER)

- Launched 2024
- Single approach for all Scottish tertiary institutions
- Peer-led, enhancement-focused
- Co-created with staff and students
- External review teams evaluate against TQEF principles
- Complies with ENQA's European Standards and Guidelines (ESG)

INTEGRATION WITH EXTERNAL FRAMEWORKS

- Scottish Credit and Qualifications Framework
- Subject Benchmark Statements
- UK Quality Code
- Bologna Process requirements
- Higher Education Achievement Records (HEAR)
- Regular international benchmarking

COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS: GLASGOW VS TRADITIONAL UK MODELS

- Enhancement focus vs compliance monitoring
- Academic autonomy with systematic support
- Genuine student partnership vs consultation
- Quality embedded in academic governance
- Cyclical review balancing accountability and autonomy
- Internal ownership ensuring authenticity

SYSTEM STRENGTHS

- Coherent integration - processes reinforce each other
- Multiple external validation mechanisms
- Internal ownership ensures sustainability
- Data-driven improvement
- Authentic student voice
- Balance of assurance and enhancement

SYSTEM WEAKNESSES

- You tell us!
- Substantial workload
- At least one part is being redeveloped at any given moment
- Evaluation fatigue from staff and students
- Meaningful engagement with the student voice
- Challenges of getting intelligent, integrated data at every level

FUTURE DIRECTIONS

- Enhanced data analytics for pattern identification
- Increased international benchmarking
- Innovation in student engagement mechanisms
- Continued evolution of partnership approaches
- Integration of emerging quality enhancement practices

CONCLUSION

- We aim for rigorous quality assurance through an enhancement focus
 - That respects academic autonomy
 - That ensures systematic oversight
 - That promotes continuous improvement
 - That is adaptable to different institutional contexts

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Slides:

